

WORLD WE LIVE ON

Our home, Planet Earth, is one of eight planets that orbit the Sun—a vast, hot star that gives out light and heat and supports life on Earth. The Sun is just one of about 200 billion stars in a galaxy called the Milky Way, itself one of about 100 billion galaxies that make up the Universe. Many of these stars have planets that orbit around them, but, as far as we know, Earth is the only planet that supports life.

The Solar System

The Earth is the third of eight spinning planets that, along with asteroids and comets, orbit the Sun, together making up the Solar System. The planets—all large balls of either rock (like Earth) or gas (like Saturn)—orbit the Sun due to its huge gravitational pull.

NEPTUNE
2.8 billion miles
(4.5 billion km)
from the Sun

SATURN
0.84 billion miles
(1.35 billion km)
from the Sun

URANUS
1.7 billion miles
(3 billion km)
from the Sun

ASTEROID
BELT

VENUS
67 million miles
(108 million km)
from the Sun

MERCURY
29 million miles
(46 million km)
from the Sun

EARTH
91 million miles
(147 million km)
from the Sun

MARS
126 million miles
(203 million km)
from the Sun

THE SUN

Shape of Earth

Due to its spherical shape, Earth spins faster at the Equator—where the circumference has farther to travel around its axis—than at the Poles, causing the planet to bulge around its middle.

Imaginary lines

To help with navigation, cartographers draw imaginary lines around Earth. Lines of latitude run parallel to the Equator, and lines of longitude are drawn from Pole to Pole.

Earth's spin

Earth spins counterclockwise on its axis—which runs from the North to the South Pole at an angle of 23.5° to the Sun—every 24 hours, giving us day and night.

21 March

It is spring in the north and fall in the south. Day and night are of equal length everywhere.

21 December

It is winter in the north and summer in the south, creating the shortest day in the north and the longest in the south.

21 June

It is summer in the north and winter in the south, creating the longest day in the north and the shortest in the south.

21 September

It is fall in the north and spring in the south. Day and night are of equal length everywhere.

The four seasons

Earth travels round the Sun once every 365.242 days (a year). As it travels it spins on its axis, causing each place on Earth to lean nearer and then farther away from the Sun over the course of a year. This gives most of the planet four distinct seasons each year with varying amounts of sunlight and darkness (daytime and nighttime).